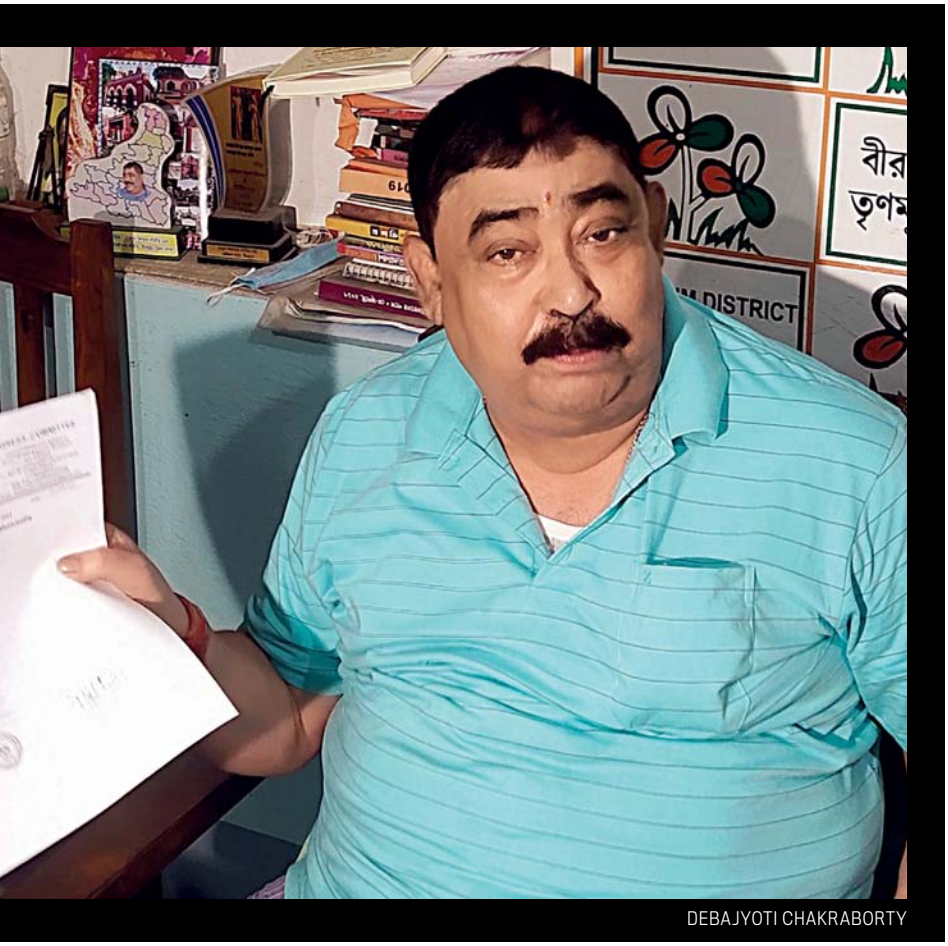


DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

UNDER THE SCANNER
Anubrata Mondal, Birbhum district chief of the Trinamool Congress

for the TMC to fund the case, which went on for a decade. Then on, the passage to area domination was seamless.

It's freely alleged that Anubrata excelled in extortion, the proceeds often being spent for the poor. "If parents had no money to marry off daughters or people couldn't afford hospital, Anubrata had it all sorted," says a neighbour in Bolpur. People also remember him sending trucks of ration from the godowns of rice mill owners to feed the activists at Singur circa 2008. Over the years, generating funds became one of Anubrata's talents—it also helped maintain his entourage and clout. A partyman and close aide lets on that Birbhum district yields Rs 200 crore a year, a substantial part of which is allegedly sent to the TMC. The party though vehemently denies such accusations as does Anubrata. Rich in mineral resources, the daily collection from illegal sand and stone mining from its quarries alone yields Rs 1-2 crore. Then there's cattle smuggling—from Birbhum to Bangladesh via Murshidabad district—for which Anubrata is in the CBI's crosshairs. With two big cattle markets, one at Illambazar and another at Sainthia, thousands of heads of cattle exchange hands daily. "Smugglers have to pay Rs 5,000 for every head of cattle smuggled out. On a daily basis, 5,000 cattle cross the Bengal-Bangladesh border from Birbhum...the haul is anything between Rs 2.5 and Rs 3 crore," says a transport operator who plies trucks in the area.

Anubrata's name is also said to figure in a diary of alleged smuggling kingpin Enamul Haque, apparently with a mention of his share of the payout.

Though Anubrata has many business interests—rice mills, goods trucks, real estate—much of his earning is allegedly generated through a superstructure of extortion. "There's a price for any favours asked, any service granted. The rate for getting a school job is Rs 10-20 lakh, it's Rs 40 lakh for colleges. In 2011-12, he allegedly gave jobs to 70 locals in primary schools for Rs 8 lakh each," says an insider. Similarly, new constructions worth Rs 9-10 crore attract a 'cut' of Rs 50 lakh. For transfers, postings, even recruitment of administrative officials, Anubrata allegedly exacts his pound of flesh—much of it reportedly given over to the party. But the Birbhum strongman dismisses all such charges as motivated and false.

It's undeniably Anubrata's dedication and street cred that make him an indispensable asset for Mamata—who indulges him despite his infamy—and Birbhum a TMC stronghold. Amazingly, for a man who has never contested an election in his 30-year political career, he remains integral to the electoral politics of Bengal and Trinamool. He's alleged to employ all means—money, threats, violence—to get the job done. During every election, the Election Commission has an eye out for him. "Twice the EC tried confiscating his mobile phones to ensure he wouldn't scare voters away or rig polls. But he couldn't be pinned down," says a farmer of Rampurhat. He remained elusive, like his menacing euphemisms: he once apparently told voters that disobedience would bring treats of *gur-batasha* (jaggery candy), an oblique reference to the colour of dried blood. In 2018, after the panchayat poll results were announced, the Supreme Court expressed "shock" at the fact that about 34 per cent—roughly 20,076 seats out of 58,692—had gone uncontested. A majority, you guessed right, were from Birbhum. The local sentiments? Less shock, more awe. ■